

Federal & Local Support for Small Business Owners

You don't have to build your business alone. Free government-backed programs offer mentoring, training, and help finding money — at every stage. Below are the main national resources. Tick the box once you've contacted each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Almost all of this help is free, funded by the SBA. You don't need to pay a consultant for advice these programs provide at no cost. Start with one and they'll point you to the rest.

1 Free Mentoring & Advising

Experienced advisors help you plan, launch, and grow — free.

☐ SCORE

Free mentoring from thousands of volunteer business experts, in person and online.

→ www.score.org

☐ Small Business Development Centers

Free, in-depth local advising on every part of your business.

→ www.sba.gov/local-assistance/resource-partners/small-business-development-centers-sbdc

2 Specialized Help Centers

SBA-funded centers focused on specific groups of entrepreneurs.

☐ Women's Business Centers

Training, counseling, and capital access for women entrepreneurs.

→ www.sba.gov/local-assistance/resource-partners/womens-business-centers

☐ Veterans Business Outreach Centers

Free business help for veterans, service members, and military spouses.

→ www.sba.gov/local-assistance/resource-partners/veterans-business-outreach-center-vboc-program

☐ MBDA Business Centers

Minority Business Development Agency centers help minority-owned firms grow and access capital.

→ www.mbda.gov/businesscenters

3 Find Your Local SBA Office

Your SBA district office connects you to all local programs and lenders.

☐ SBA District Office Finder

Find the SBA office near you for in-person help and local resources.

→ www.sba.gov/local-assistance/find

4 Local Economic Development

Cities and states offer their own incentives, grants, and support.

☐ Your State / City Economic Development Office

Most states and many cities have offices that help businesses with funding and incentives. Search your state + "economic development."

→ Search your state + 'economic development office'

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Be cautious of private "business grant" consultants charging big fees for what SCORE, SBDCs, and SBA offices do for free. Stick with the official SBA resource partners first.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

These advisors often know about local grants, low-interest loans, and contracts you'd never find on your own. One free meeting can open several doors.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national programs. For your nearest SBA office, women's/veterans'/minority business center, and local incentives, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
